

Meditazione Guidata Dettagliata Vipassanā

Bhante Bodhidhamma · International Talks · 43:36

Detailed guided meditation. Instructions on how to practice *Vipassanā Bhāvanā*, insight meditation, as it was transmitted by Mahāsi Sayādaw, Burmese master.

First of all we must arrange the body in a meditative position. Some sit on a chair, others use a stool, but the usual position is sitting on a cushion on the floor with a cross-legged posture. The hands should rest on the lap, preferably the left on the right. Whatever posture you adopt you should feel comfortable from the beginning.

Then make sure that the spine is straight while maintaining its natural curvature. It's better not to lean against anything since this will induce sleep. Now imagine a puppet string that starts from the base of the spinal column and reaches the top of the head and that it is gently pulled so that all the vertebrae are separated and there is the sensation of becoming tall and light, a sensation of energy that flows along the spine without tensions or contractions. And the head should feel balanced above. Let everything relax from that central column.

Here we can help ourselves to relax with some simple exercises. First of all, let's see how much we can relax simply by telling the muscles to relax. Start from the top of the head. Go down along the forehead, the eyes, the cheeks, the jaw, the neck, the shoulders, the arms and the hands. Feel how everything becomes heavier when tension stops supporting them. Now return to the chest. Relax it. Go down along the body to the stomach, to the abdomen, relaxing as much as possible. And finally feel the legs heavy on the floor.

The superficial tension should have loosened a bit now, even just a bit, but we might feel a deeper level of tension, more habitual and therefore not easy to relax with an act of mental will. Here we can use a second technique for muscular tension. Where you feel tension, tense the muscles of that area as much as possible and release them slowly. This is particularly useful if you have tensions in the face. Scrunch up the face as much as possible, hold and relax. Let's try again. Hold... relax. It's also good for the neck and shoulders. Stiffen the whole area, hold and release slowly. Try again. Stiffen the whole area, the neck, the shoulders, hold and relax slowly.

A third technique is the best for chest tensions although it has an effect on the whole body. Controlled breathing. Take a slow and deep breath. Fill the lungs completely. Hold the breath as long as possible and let go quickly of the entire rib cage throwing out the air. Then, to avoid hyperventilation, wait for the next breath to arise naturally. Now let's take a deep breath. Hold it and let it go. Let's try again. Take a deep breath, hold it and let it go.

At this point you should have developed a deep relaxation. So now we should find ourselves in a position favourable to meditation. The spine should be energised, but not tense. The rest of the body should feel relaxed, as if it were letting go from this central spinal column. And the head should be in balance, symbolising the balance between physical vigilance and relaxation.

Now see for a few moments if you can feel this position as a whole and recognise the qualities of alert energy united with a calm relaxation. Now we must develop the same sense of energetic vigilance and a calm relaxed state in the mind. And to achieve this we use the breath.

Put your attention on the abdomen and feel the movement of rising and falling as you breathe naturally. Bear in mind that this is not a breathing technique. You must not interfere with the breath. It might happen that breathing is not so evident in the abdomen, in which case see if you can feel the chest rising and falling. You can also use the breath at the nostrils, but for the Mahāsi technique it's preferable to use the abdomen. See which is the most evident for you.

Whatever point of the body you have chosen, this is your primary object of observation. This means that you will use this point to develop an alert and calm awareness. If you move from one point to another, for example from the nose to the abdomen, this will weaken your ability to concentrate. That is to say the ability to observe with an alert but calm attention, without the mind flying away.

If you are watching the process of breathing at the abdomen or chest, observe the movement, the rising and falling and use a mental label to calm the thinking process. With the inspiration notice "rising, rising" and with the expiration notice "falling, falling". After the expiration, sometimes the inspiration starts immediately without pause, but when you begin to relax, a pause will begin to appear. It might be that there is a pause before the inspiration, right from the beginning. Here there is the danger that the mind runs away behind fantasies. To prevent this from happening, we choose a contact point. It could be the sensation of your hands on your lap or the sensation of the legs on the floor. Choose what is most evident.

So, as you feel the abdomen or chest rising with inspiration, feel those sensations. Observe them carefully and point your attention directly there, noting "rising, rising". Do the same as you feel the abdomen or chest falling with expiration. Feel the sensations, the sensations of movement. Observe them carefully and notice "falling, falling". If there is a pause before inspiration, notice a contact point, "touching, touching". Make sure, as soon as it begins, to return immediately to the abdomen or chest.

If you are concentrating on the nostrils, it's the same, with the difference that it would be more appropriate to use the mental labels "in, in", "out, out", remembering to concentrate on the sensations at the nostrils or upper lip, wherever the passage of air is felt most clearly.

Keep in mind that it doesn't matter how many times you say the mental label. Once might be sufficient. The important thing is to pay attention to the sensations as they arise. The word itself has little importance. It's just a simple and very effective way of stopping the wandering mind. What you must pay

attention to are all the sensations caused by the breathing process.

Now you might discover that the mind wanders towards thoughts or fantasies. When you awaken, simply notice "thinking, thinking", "dreaming, dreaming", once or twice. And then quickly and firmly return to observing the sensations of breathing. But you must not be harsh or force. Training the mind is a bit like training a little dog to sit. When it gets up, you have to stroke it gently but firmly. If you get angry and hit it, it will only want to run away.

So now let's practice this meditation on breathing for a while, as we observe and notice all the sensations. Rising, falling, touching. If your mind is wandering, notice what it was doing—dreaming, thinking, worrying and so on—and bring it back gently but firmly to the breath. If you feel sleepy, put more energy into the spine. Sit straight, but not tense.

This part of the meditation has the main purpose of developing concentration. It's normal for at least ten minutes to pass before the mind becomes quite calm, at least until the grossest agitation has gone away and you have managed to observe the object, in this case the breath, quite regularly. We use the breath because it's a neutral sensation, it doesn't agitate us or depress us. So the mind stops and goes towards a level of concentration through calm and peace.

This is different from the type of concentration we get when we do or see something engaging, like watching a film or when we have to do work carefully. In these cases the type of concentration depends on external stimuli, but the concentration we need for insight must arise from a tranquil and still mind. And when this type of tranquil, concentrated mind develops, we discover that another faculty becomes relevant, our intuitive intelligence, *paññā*.

Sometimes, when you try to listen to a short-wave radio, there's so much interference that it's difficult to hear exactly what is being said. Once the disturbance disappears, everything becomes clear. And so it is with *paññā*, our intuitive intelligence. Once the mind is calm and concentrated and the activities of thinking and imagining cease, intuitive intelligence is able to see and understand clearly what is happening.

So, now what we must do is develop this concentrated attention, animated by intelligence, *satipaññā*, not only on the breath, but on anything that enters our field of consciousness. The example I like to give is that of the birdwatcher. They sit in a hide, hidden from the birds they are observing. In this way the birds are not disturbed and you can observe their natural habits. All the knowledge regarding feeding, nesting, mating, et cetera, is had simply by observing, simply by looking.

In the same way, the ability to be simple observers interested in discovering the true nature of our body, mind and heart, is the key to spiritual insight. But this observing, be clear, is not a searching for something. We are not looking for something. We are simple observers who do not interfere, who simply look at what enters their field of consciousness. Simply looking at what arises in the here and now, while

it's happening, without thoughts about it or questions.

So we begin by developing attention on the breath. Should we hear a sound? We notice it immediately, noting "hearing, hearing". Now, try to catch the quality of the sound right at the ear. In this way we will hold the mind from flying away, so to speak, towards the object, whether it's the chirping of a bird or a car passing by, and we will avoid starting an entire chain of imaginative thoughts. The same goes for a smell. Notice it for what it is. "Smelling, smelling", right there at the nostrils.

Again with any sensation of the body, like itching or tingling, or the sensation of contact of the legs on the floor, simply notice "itching, itching", "heaviness, heaviness", right there where the sensations are felt. Immerse yourself in them with attention.

Then there are sensations that arise in the body, like heat and cold, heaviness and lightness, all types of pain, discomfort and pleasure. You can use a particular word like hot or cold, where appropriate, or you can use a general word, like "feeling". Now it's important not to react to these sensations, unless they are too strong to bear.

Remember that the mental label is a technique we use to keep attention stable on the object. In other words, it controls the faculty of thinking, but the attention itself should penetrate into the actual sensation.

Then there are sensations in the body that arise from moods and emotions, the unpleasant ones like fear, depression and guilt, and the pleasant ones like laziness, joy and love. Here we can use specific words like guilt, love, but continuing to fully feel the mood or emotions, the actual sensations wherever they present themselves, like in the chest, in the stomach or in the abdomen, even in the head.

Finally there are thoughts and images. Notice them as "thinking" or "imagining" and they will end. Otherwise they will drag you into a daydream, sometimes for the entire period of meditation. And pay particular attention to the judging mind. "It's terrible, it's not good, this is fine, it's beautiful", and so on. Don't correct or interfere with such thoughts. Simply recognise them and notice "judging, judging".

We are not trying to become spectators, involved in all the mental games, supporting one position rather than another. We must assume the position of the observer, an objective observer, simply allowing all the games to unfold right here in front of our eyes. And all the time we try to maintain that separation, that distance, that detachment from anything that happens in the body, in the mind and in the heart. We observe all these psychophysical events as something else, as if they belonged to another person. In this way we can investigate objectively.

So, whatever is offered, a sensation, an emotion, a thought, simply observe it, with attention. Feel it fully, experience it directly. Now let's sit and with keen interest watch the flow of physical and mental phenomena.

Always begin with the breath. Rising, falling, touching. If the mind wanders notice what it was

doing—dreaming, thinking, worrying and so on—and bring it back to the breath firmly but gently. If there is laziness, energise the spine. Re-establish the posture. Slowly, very slowly, or you might disturb your concentration. Notice the entire movement. "Straightening, straightening."

Sometimes there is much pain. Disturbances and tensions arise in the body. This will not depend on the posture, if it is correct. They will probably be caused by unresolved emotions or mental states that have been suppressed and pushed out of consciousness. It's important to relax towards them and develop an attitude of interest.

These disturbances, sometimes very bothersome, might continue for the duration of an entire session and for many sessions until they resolve. It might be that the underlying reason, like an emotion, doesn't manifest. Only when the disturbance has passed will it indicate that healing has occurred. We must develop patience to endure this type of thing and use the opportunity to see pain as pain, just sensation, and separate the suffering, which is the aversion or fear that we feel.

We take both parts, the painful sensations and the mental attitudes as objects to notice, observe and understand. So continue to notice, continue to observe, maintaining a sharp attention. If you get lost, begin again from the breath, your home base and anchor.

Always begin from the breath, rising, falling, touching. If the mind wanders, bring it back firmly but gently to the primary object, the breath. If there is tiredness or numbness, make the energy rise up the spine by sitting straight, but not tense, remember. Be particularly attentive to attention around the shoulders, neck and jaw.

And here we are sitting inside ourselves, so to speak, watching an internal film. The body, mind and heart put on a show just as they want. We don't interfere. It's a natural process of revelation. With time many things that have been suppressed for a long time might arise from the unconscious. They will reveal themselves when it's the right time and when we are ready to accept them. In this way insight meditation performs psychotherapy.

Even painful traumatic memories from childhood will in time be removed from the system and with them all the obsessions and tensions they have caused. All we have to do to achieve this purification of the heart is to remain firm in our observation post.

Now, even though our psychological purification will happen naturally, this is not the goal of meditation. The purpose of our practice is to go to the deeper levels to see first of all why suffering arises. One way is to notice the relationship we have with whatever we are observing. The mind continuously jumps from attraction to repulsion, from wanting what it likes to not wanting what it doesn't like.

This type of involvement is simply a way in which we try to find happiness in pleasant states and escape unhappiness by running away from unpleasant states. This constant oscillation, this bouncing from greed to aversion to new greed, this is what, in the second noble truth, the Buddha said is the cause of our

dissatisfaction.

So, as pleasant and unpleasant objects arise, we must carefully notice this secondary reaction of grasping them and pushing them away, sometimes moving away with fear, the twin sister of aversion. In this way this reaction will cool down and might even be exhausted and we will experience a deeply satisfying equanimous mind. In turn this will allow us to investigate more deeply into the causes of suffering.

So let all that pain and pleasure come to the surface and express itself. Observe the reaction, the grasping, the aversion, the fear. "Desire, desire", "aversion, aversion", "fear, fear".

Begin again with the breath. Rising, falling, touching. If the mind wanders notice what it was doing and re-establish your concentration on the breath. If you are sleepy sit straight and make the energy rise along the spine.

As you begin to deepen your awareness of all the phenomena that arise in your body, mind and heart, you will become increasingly aware of what the Buddha called the three characteristics of existence. The first is the fact of transience. Everything arises and vanishes.

The second is the difficult teaching of not-self. As you watch all these physical and mental phenomena, you will notice that they arise on their own, there's no one controlling them. They have a life of their own, their own energy. Sometimes the body, mind and heart might seem distant, another thing. Before we talked about my sensations, my thoughts, my emotions. But now we find ourselves pointing to them, so to speak, through the technique of noting. There is a sensation, there is a thought, there is an emotion.

We are slowly moving from a relationship of identity and possession. I am seeing. I am what I think. I am what I feel. I have a body. I have a mind. I have a heart. Instead we are approaching towards a position of detachment. This is the beginning of the experience of not-self.

We discover that the psychophysical organism that we call me does not constitute anything substantial. It's made up of many parts that work in unison, just like a car, but there's no central nucleus, no substance exists.

Third point, as we have noted, every time we enter into a relationship of attachment, desire or aversion to the body, mind or heart, identity and possession follows and suffering ensues. This is the characteristic of dissatisfaction. We should develop an attitude towards the body, mind and heart, like that of one who rents a house, not one who owns it.

It is the observation of these three characteristics of transience, insubstantiality and dissatisfaction that leads to spiritual insights, that liberate consciousness from its illusions and leads to liberation from all suffering. And it is this practice of *Vipassanā* that is the tool we use.

This bare attention, simply observing everything that arises and passes. This choiceless awareness, which doesn't control or manipulate. This impartial observation, which doesn't question or judge. This intuitive

introspection, fully experiencing every phenomenon as it truly is. This is the faculty of intuitive awareness, *satipaṇṇā*, precisely the faculty that will bring in time to the realisation of *Nibbāna*.

Il non nato, il non divenuto, il non creato, l'incondizionato.

Tutto ciò che dobbiamo fare è osservare, solo osservare, qualunque cosa sorga, mentre sorge e passa. Ricominciate con il respiro: salire, scendere, toccare.

Durante la vita quotidiana, sedersi così anche solo per qualche momento, abbastanza per ristabilire un'attenzione calma e vigile, impedirà alle nostre emozioni di avere un effetto valanga. Minimizzerà le cause dello stress. Quindici minuti potrebbero essere sufficienti per ristabilire il nostro centro.

Con l'esercizio, questo può diventare uno stato mentale regolare, invece di qualcosa che avviene solo in determinate condizioni. Questo cuore calmo e questa mente vigile sono lo stato in cui dovremmo trovarci sempre, anche sotto stress.

È all'interno di questo ambiente interno che questa consapevolezza intuitiva, *satipaṇṇā*, può operare. Altrimenti si perde, sommersa e controllata da pensieri ed emozioni che sfuggono al controllo. Dovremmo costantemente sforzarci di riguadagnare e mantenere questa posizione interiore. Questo è vivere in piena coscienza.

In questo modo, la pratica di vipassanā, la meditazione dell'insight, penetrerà in ogni momento della nostra vita e noi saremo premiati con grandi benefici.

Ora, quando giungete alla fine di un periodo di meditazione, non saltatene fuori, ma uscite lentamente. Prima aprite gli occhi, fate entrare la luce, delicatamente dondolatevi da una parte all'altra e alzatevi lentamente e con consapevolezza. In questo modo potrete mantenere la vostra consapevolezza intuitiva, *satipaṇṇā*.

Possiate essere in buona salute. Possiate essere felici. Possiate presto essere liberi da tutta la vostra sofferenza. Possiate sperimentare la pace e beatitudine del *Nibbāna*.

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